



Grade 4
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 4 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

Read the passage.

Esme's Big Day

The sky above is clear and bright,
But I am filled with doubt and fright.
Soccer tryouts are here today.
Will I shine bright, or will my dream fade away?

- 5 "I am ready!" I bellow inside my head,
but I mostly wish I were back in bed.
The grassy field is an endless sea,
My legs shake as I wonder, "Is this really me?"

- The other girls seem sure and strong.
10 I am not certain if I even belong.
We stand in a line—the ball smacks the ground.
Thump-thump! Thump-thump! My heart starts to pound.

- "Esme!" Coach calls. "Kick the ball toward the goal!"
I kick it and kick it and watch it roll.
15 I dash down the field as fast as the breeze.
There is an opportunity here to seize.

- I smack the ball, and it sails to the net!
But then it goes wild, so I am upset.
I try again—this time it goes in!
20 **beam** ear to ear and hold up my chin.

I watch as the other girls each take a turn.
They are so good; I know I still have a lot to learn.
They dash and they dart—it's almost a dance.
I think I can do it—just give me a chance!

- 25 My heart is as light as a fluffy, white cloud.
Someday soon I will play before a huge crowd.
The weeks will drag by until that wonderful day.
I cannot wait, I cannot wait! I am ready to play!

1. Read the first lines from the poem.

The sky above is clear and bright,
But I am filled with doubt and fright.

Why does the poem begin with these lines?

- A. to hint at what will happen later
 - B. to contrast Esme's feelings with the setting
 - C. to show what Esme thinks about the weather
 - D. to explain why it is a good day for playing soccer
2. How are lines 13–20 MOST important to the plot in the poem?
- A. The lines explain why Coach appears to be shouting at Esme.
 - B. The lines show how Esme becomes successful at showing her skills at tryouts.
 - C. The lines explain how Esme knows she will someday play before a huge crowd.
 - D. The lines show why Esme has a wider range of skills than some of the other girls at tryouts.
3. Which line from the poem uses a simile to show Esme's eagerness?
- A. My legs shake as I wonder, "Is this really me?"
 - B. Thump-thump! Thump-thump! My heart starts to pound.
 - C. I dash down the field as fast as the breeze.
 - D. I think I can do it—just give me a chance!

4. This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.

Part A

What is the main lesson that Esme learns in the poem?

- A. One person's courage can help others.
- B. One player can help a team be successful.
- C. Soccer is a sport that requires patience and practice.
- D. Things that seem difficult at first can become enjoyable.

Part B

Which line from the poem BEST supports the answer to Part A?

- A. There is an opportunity here to seize.
 - B. They are so good; I know I still have a lot to learn.
 - C. I think I can do it—just give me a chance!
 - D. The weeks will drag by until that wonderful day.
5. Which word is a synonym for **beam** in line 20 of the poem?
- A. flash
 - B. look
 - C. scowl
 - D. smile

6. Read the stanza from the poem.

I watch as the other girls each take a turn.
They are so good; I know I still have a lot to learn.
They dash and they dart—it's almost a dance.
I think I can do it—just give me a chance!

What is the purpose of these lines from the poem?

- A. to show that Esme wishes she were somewhere else
 - B. to show that the girls perform at different levels during tryouts
 - C. to show that Esme feels left out because the girls are avoiding her
 - D. to show that the girls are celebrating how well the tryouts are going
- 7. Select **two** statements that show themes found in “Esme’s Big Day.”**
- A. Everyone has talents to be developed.
 - B. Hard work earns the respect of others.
 - C. Helping others shows respect and understanding.
 - D. A positive attitude can bring courage in difficult situations.
 - E. The best way to achieve a goal is to accept help when needed.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 8. Which sentence contains the correct verb tense of the word **go**?
- A. Each morning, he goes to the diner and buys a cup of coffee.
 - B. Each morning, he went to the diner and buys a cup of coffee.
 - C. Each morning, he will go to the diner and buys a cup of coffee.
 - D. Each morning, he was going to the diner and buys a cup of coffee.

- ★ 9. **Read the sentence.**

"You are OUT!" the umpire **said** as the player slid into home plate.

Which word BEST replaces the word **said** to make the sentence more precise?

- A. reminded
- B. replied
- C. shouted
- D. stated

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 10. **Read the sentence.**

She had been waiting for this day for weeks today was the day her new puppy was coming home!

What is the BEST way to correct the run-on sentence?

- A. She had been waiting for this day for weeks, today was the day. Her new puppy was coming home!
- B. She had been waiting for this day for weeks. Today was the day her new puppy was coming home!
- C. She had been waiting for this day for weeks today was the day, and her new puppy was coming home!
- D. She had been waiting for this day for weeks, and today was the day, now her new puppy was coming home!

Read the passage.

Boots on the Moon

- 1 Many of us have gazed at the moon. The moon is about 239,000 miles away from Earth. Most of us will never get there. But some people have really stood on the moon and gazed back at Earth. These space travelers were astronauts who took part in missions to explore the moon.

The Apollo Program

- 2 During the 1960s, the United States of America was in a race with other countries to put the first astronaut on the moon. The goal was to land people on the moon and bring them safely back to Earth. That is how the Apollo Program, also known as Project Apollo, began.
- 3 The Apollo Program ran from 1961 to 1972. The program had many missions. Only 12 of those missions sent people to space. Most of the early missions only orbited the moon. By the year 1969, no one had landed on the moon. But that was all about to change.

Apollo 11: The First Moonwalk

- 4 Apollo 11, the sixth mission with people, was the first to land on the moon. The flight crew consisted of three astronauts: Commander Neil Armstrong, Buzz Aldrin, and Michael Collins. For months, the astronauts practiced and prepared. On July 16, 1969, they were ready. Apollo 11 blasted off from Kennedy Space Center. More than 600 million people watched the **launch** on their televisions. They cheered for the history-making moment.
- 5 Apollo 11 landed on the moon on July 20. Armstrong was the first astronaut to **emerge** from the spacecraft. As he stepped onto the moon's surface, he said, "That's one small step for a man, one giant leap for mankind."
- 6 During this mission, Armstrong and Aldrin explored the moon for 2 hours and 32 minutes. They collected samples, conducted experiments, and took photographs. They used special tools designed for their mission. Because their spacesuits were bulky, it was difficult for the astronauts to move and bend. Special rakes, scoops, hammers, and tubes had long handles that allowed the astronauts to collect rocks and soil without bending.
- 7 Apollo 11 carried the first rock samples back to Earth, but the astronauts left some things on the moon too. They left an American flag, an arm patch from Apollo 1, and a metal sign with a message on it. Apollo 11 returned to Earth on July 24, 1969.

Apollo 12–Apollo 16

- 8 Between 1969 and 1972, America launched five more Apollo missions. During those missions, eight more astronauts put their boots on the moon.
- 9 One mission, Apollo 13, was not able to land on the moon because of an emergency. The astronauts and spacecraft were brought safely back to Earth.

Apollo 17: The Last Moonwalk

- 10 Apollo 17, the final mission, lifted off on December 7, 1972. It was the first nighttime liftoff in the history of American space travel. The three-person crew included Commander Eugene Cernan, Harrison Schmitt, and Ronald Evans.
- 11 Apollo 17 landed on the moon on December 11. Cernan and Schmitt climbed out of the spacecraft. When Schmitt's feet hit the ground, he became the first geologist, or rock scientist, to put boots on the moon.
- 12 Cernan and Schmitt spent a total of 74 hours, 59 minutes, and 40 seconds on the moon. They had a tool that had never been used before—a battery-powered vehicle. The vehicle could carry two astronauts, tools, equipment, and samples. The two astronauts traveled almost 22 miles across the moon's surface. They brought back more samples than any of the other Apollo missions.
- 13 Apollo 17 left the moon on December 14. As Cernan's boots left the surface, he said, "As we leave the Moon . . . we leave as we came . . . with peace and hope for all mankind." The astronauts returned to Earth on December 19, 1972.

After the Apollo Program

- 14 All together, the Apollo missions brought back 842 pounds of materials from the moon's surface. Astronauts collected rocks, pebbles, dirt, sand, and dust from six different places on the moon. These samples helped scientists understand how the solar system formed. Even now, many years later, moon samples are still being shared with scientists and teachers. The Apollo program may have ended, but its discoveries continue to teach us about space.

11. This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.

Part A

Which sentence describes how the author organizes MOST of the passage?

- A. The author compares the Apollo program to other space programs.
- B. The author lists events from the Apollo program in order of importance.
- C. The author explains a problem that the Apollo program was able to solve.
- D. The author talks about what the Apollo program accomplished over its years.

Part B

How does the structure affect the meaning of the passage?

- A. It shows the weaknesses of the Apollo program.
- B. It shows how the Apollo program helped people.
- C. It shows the history of the Apollo space program.
- D. It shows how the Apollo program affected Americans.

12. Which phrase from paragraph 4 BEST helps the reader understand the meaning of **launch**?

- A. were ready
- B. blasted off
- C. on their televisions
- D. history-making moment

13. Why does the author describe the work astronauts did on the moon?

- A. to tell what the astronauts brought with them to the moon
- B. to show that it was difficult to walk on the surface of the moon
- C. to show that one goal of the missions was to better understand the moon
- D. to tell how skilled the astronauts were in using technology during their missions on the moon

14. Which effects happened because of the causes in the chart?

Write the letter for each effect in the correct box in the chart.

- A. Scientists better understood how the solar system was formed.
- B. The astronauts could gather rocks without bending over.
- C. Project Apollo began and ran many missions.

Cause	Effect
The United States was in a race to put the first astronaut on the moon.	
The astronauts collected samples from different places on the moon.	
The astronauts used special tools with long handles.	

15. What does the word **emerge** mean in paragraph 5?

- A. land
- B. jump
- C. enter
- D. appear

16. What does paragraph 12 indicate about the later Apollo missions?
- A. It was easier to carry things to Earth.
 - B. The technology that was used had improved.
 - C. It took longer to land on the surface of the Moon.
 - D. The astronauts were more interested in space travel.
17. Why was Apollo 11 an important mission in the Apollo program?
- A. It was the first mission where a spacecraft lifted off at night.
 - B. It was the final mission where the most moon samples were collected.
 - C. It was the first mission in the world where a person walked on the moon.
 - D. It was the mission where astronauts safely returned to Earth after an emergency.

18. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

What is the central idea of the passage?

- A. The Apollo Program allowed several astronauts to walk on the moon.
- B. The Apollo 13 mission had an emergency that made the crew return home.
- C. The Apollo missions were seen on television and watched by many people.
- D. The Apollo astronauts used special tools to collect rocks and soil from the moon.

Part B

How does the author support the answer to Part A?

- A. by telling how the astronauts were shown on television
- B. by naming the astronauts who stood on the surface of the moon
- C. by describing how the astronauts trained and prepared for their missions
- D. by explaining how the astronauts collected samples and brought them back to Earth

The item on this page is not passage-based.

- ★ 19. A.J. is writing a paragraph about why Chimney Rock is important to the history of Nebraska. He found this information in an online source.

Pioneers used Chimney Rock in their travels on the California, Mormon, and Oregon trails. It helped to mark the trail during the time when people were traveling west across the state of Nebraska. Chimney Rock is located about four miles south of the small town of Bayard. It is a natural rock tower made from years of wind and water wearing away the bluffs at the edge of the North Platte Valley. From its cone-shaped base to its tall peak at its top, it rises 325 feet. In the last 150 years, however, the rock has lost 30 feet in height because of lightning and weather conditions. Chimney Rock is made up of layers of Brule clay and volcanic ash that date to between 23 and 34 million years ago. This wonderful creation stands 480 feet above the North Platte River Valley in the state of Nebraska.

Which sentence from the source could A.J. use to BEST help answer his research question?

- A. It helped to mark the trail during the time when people were traveling west across the state of Nebraska.
- B. It is a natural rock tower made from years of wind and water wearing away the bluffs at the edge of the North Platte Valley.
- C. In the last 150 years, however, the rock has lost 30 feet in height because of lightning and weather conditions.
- D. This wonderful creation stands 480 feet above the North Platte River Valley in the state of Nebraska.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 20. **Read the source.**

The debate over Nebraska's statehood was due to a question about states' rights. The United States government insisted it could decide who could vote, but Nebraska did not think the United States should tell them who could vote. In January of 1867, Congress passed a bill to allow Nebraska and Colorado to become states. Before the end of the month, President Andrew Johnson attempted to veto, or say no to, Nebraska becoming a state. However, Congress decided to go against President Johnson and allow Nebraska to become a state.

Now read the student's paragraph.

The Nebraska Territory was established in 1854. People in the Nebraska Territory first voted on statehood in 1860, but statehood did not pass. Several years later, it was a different story. Voters wanted the territory to become a state, but at that time the president said no. President Andrew Johnson attempted to veto, or say no to, Nebraska becoming a state in January of 1867. Congress voted against President Johnson. Nebraska was named a part of the United States that March. Something similar happened to Colorado, but Colorado failed where Nebraska succeeded.

Which statement from the paragraph did the student plagiarize from the source?

- A. People in the Nebraska Territory first voted on statehood in 1860, but statehood did not pass.
- B. President Andrew Johnson attempted to veto, or say no to, Nebraska becoming a state in January of 1867.
- C. Nebraska was named a part of the United States that March.
- D. Something similar happened to Colorado, but Colorado failed where Nebraska succeeded.

**NSCAS General Grade 4
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points								
1	B	1								
2	B	1								
3	C	1								
4	Part A: D Part B: D	2								
5	D	1								
6	B	1								
7	A, D	2								
8	A	1								
9	C	1								
10	B	1								
11	Part A: D Part B: C	2								
12	B	1								
13	C	1								
14	<table><tr><th>Cause</th><th>Effect</th></tr><tr><td>The United States was in a race to put the first astronaut on the moon.</td><td>Project Apollo began and ran many missions.</td></tr><tr><td>The astronauts collected samples from different places on the moon.</td><td>Scientists better understood how the solar system was formed.</td></tr><tr><td>The astronauts used special tools with long handles.</td><td>The astronauts could gather rocks without bending over.</td></tr></table>	Cause	Effect	The United States was in a race to put the first astronaut on the moon.	Project Apollo began and ran many missions.	The astronauts collected samples from different places on the moon.	Scientists better understood how the solar system was formed.	The astronauts used special tools with long handles.	The astronauts could gather rocks without bending over.	2
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15	D	1								
16	B	1								
17	C	1								
18	Part A: A Part B: B	2								
19	A	1								
20	B	1								